

From Glory to Glory in My New Nature

Open to Galatians 2, and then we will go over to Romans and begin around verse 11.

We have come to the point where we are studying the covenant with Abraham and our sonship. That covenant was fulfilled in our sonship. To understand it further, we have to go back under the law and study the encounter Paul had with Peter.

The church at Antioch was started through Paul and Barnabas. After the devil began bringing believers back under the law, men came from Jerusalem to Antioch, and then that influence moved on to Galatia.

I believe with all my heart that Paul was born out of due season. He said:

"This gospel I received not of man,
neither was I taught it, but by the revelation of Jesus Christ."

So when Paul speaks here, he is saying, "What I am about to say to you, I did not receive from another apostle. Jesus Christ taught it to me directly."

The Galatians were trying to go back under the law because the Judaizers had made it as far as Galatia. Judaizers were people who had been born again but were trying to require Gentiles to keep the law after receiving Christ. They would say, "Paul is deceived. Once a Gentile becomes Abraham's seed through the new birth, he must go on and keep the law."

Paul tells the Galatians, "You want to go back under the law? Then listen closely."

We have found that the law was added to the Abrahamic covenant because of transgressions. There was one Old Testament covenant cut with Abraham, and the law was added to that.

Galatians asks:

"Wherefore then serveth the law?"

It was added because of transgressions until the Seed should come.

So Paul is saying, "If you want to go back under that portion of the law, then hear what the law says."

This was an incredible time in history. The Gentile church often understands very little about the purpose the law served. Paul says some very strong things, and to understand their strength, we must go back through Romans and Second Corinthians before returning to Galatians.

One of my favorite chapters now is one I avoided for fifteen years: Galatians 4. Paul says the heir is no different from the servant. It becomes even stronger when you find out the word means slave.

The heir he is speaking of in context is the Jew, because he is warning Gentiles who wanted to go back under the law. God came to earth and solicited Israel as a client nation. Somebody had to work in the Father's house. Somebody had to do the ordinances, serve Him, lay the foundation, and give God authority in the earth to bring Jesus Christ in.

To them were committed the oracles of God. The promises began with one man, Abraham, and came through that people. But Israel still had to be born again just as much as anyone else.

One spirit behind Paul's confrontation with Peter at Antioch is the idea that the Jew is saved without being born again. That is not true. You cannot be saved without being born again.

For two thousand years, generations of Jews have lived and died rejecting Christ. There is a prophesied revival when their heart turns to Him and they say, "You are Him." But the fact that such a revival is coming does not mean Jews are saved without receiving Jesus.

When I have talked with teachers and historians who defend the Jewish place in history, I often ask about those generations. Some want them saved so badly that they say, "I believe God knows in their heart whether they would have accepted Christ, so they are saved." But Scripture does not teach salvation without the new birth.

That is why Galatians 4 matters. The heir is no different from the slave. The Jew who stood to inherit was no different from the Gentile slave to sin until he received the new nature.

The law also placed them under a curse:

"Cursed is every one that continueth not in all things which are written in the book of the law to do them."

Second Corinthians calls the whole administration of the law "the ministration of death" and "the ministration of condemnation." What was engraved in stones? The Ten Commandments. That is heavy, but it is what Paul says.

The Jew was called to serve in God's house and stood with the promise of sonship, but he had the same nature as the Gentile. The curse came because a spiritually dead man was given the Ten Commandments and told to keep them.

They could not. That is why animals had to be sacrificed.

Jesus said:

"The servant abideth not in the house for ever:
but the Son abideth ever."

If you know the truth, the Son will make you free by making you a son. You stand to inherit everything the Father has, but not until your nature changes.

Second Corinthians 3:2-3 says:

"Ye are our epistle written in our hearts,
known and read of all men:
Forasmuch as ye are manifestly declared to be the epistle of Christ ministered by us,
written not with ink,
but with the Spirit of the living God;
not in tables of stone,
but in fleshy tables of the heart."

Paul was so full of the law and the Abrahamic covenant that he could hardly teach Gentiles without getting into it.

This is the same thing Hebrews speaks of when God says the new covenant would not be like the one made with the fathers in the wilderness. The laws would no longer be merely on tablets of stone. God would write them in hearts and minds.

The Ten Commandments described the righteousness of God, but a spiritually dead man could not keep them. Paul said:

"I had not known sin, but by the law."

If you are born with a sin nature and have never known anything else, someone must tell you what you are. The law came as a schoolmaster, slapped the spiritually dead man into a chair, and said, "I will prove to you that you are a sinner. Quit coveting."

He answered, "I cannot."

Then he had to kill another animal.

In the covenant God promised, every man would not have to teach his neighbor to know God by external ordinances and commandments. The laws would be written into hearts and minds.

That means the believer would be born again and receive a nature that can keep those laws.

Now you are an epistle written by the Spirit. Now the righteousness of the law can be fulfilled in you because you no longer walk after the flesh, but after the spirit. You have the nature the Ten Commandments described.

From the least believer to the greatest apostle, all can know Him because He wrote His laws in the heart.

That is also the law of conscience Paul speaks of in Romans 2. The born-again conscience tells you what is right and wrong. If someone says, "I did not know adultery was wrong," or, "I did not know lying was wrong," that person is defending a wrong position. The new conscience

immediately bears witness to what is right.

God could not judge you according to that conscience if it were not alive in you.

Second Corinthians 3:3 says the epistle is written by the Spirit of the living God, not on stone but in the heart.

This is what Galatians is talking about when Paul says:

"O foolish Galatians...
having begun in the Spirit, are ye now made perfect by the flesh?"

He asks whether the one who ministers the Spirit among them does it by the works of the law or by the hearing of faith.

What Spirit is he talking about there? Not primarily the baptism of the Holy Ghost. He is talking about the born-again experience that replaced the tablets of stone and made them living epistles. The issue in Galatians is righteousness by faith, not the gift of the Holy Ghost as a separate subject.

The Greek word for spirit is the same whether it refers to the Holy Spirit or the human spirit. The sentence structure tells you which is meant. In many passages we have applied to the Holy Ghost, Paul is actually talking about the born-again human spirit.

Second Corinthians 3:6 says God:

"Hath made us able ministers of the new testament;
not of the letter, but of the spirit:
for the letter killeth,
but the spirit giveth life."

Then Paul goes back to the letter, the Ten Commandments:

"But if the ministration of death,
written and engraven in stones,
was glorious..."

What was engraved in stones? The Ten Commandments.

Paul calls them the ministration of death and the ministration of condemnation because a spiritually dead man could not keep them. The commandment exposed his nature. It said, "Do not covet," and he found that he could not stop.

The law did its job as schoolmaster. It proved he needed another nature.

But the ministration of righteousness exceeds in glory because I am no longer standing back admiring a nature I should have. I have become that nature through the new birth.

Second Corinthians 3:11-15 says:

"For if that which is done away was glorious,
much more that which remaineth is glorious.
Seeing then that we have such hope,
we use great plainness of speech:
And not as Moses,
which put a veil over his face,
that the children of Israel could not stedfastly look to the end of that which is abolished...
But even unto this day, when Moses is read,
the veil is upon their heart."

The veil over Moses' face represented spiritual death. Israel could not look to the end of what was abolished because they did not have the nature that could keep the glory represented in the law.

The same veil remains when Moses is read, until the heart turns to the Lord.

Paul says:

"Nevertheless when it shall turn to the Lord,
the veil shall be taken away."

When the heart turns, the veil of spiritual death is removed, and the man can finally look upon that glory because he has a nature that can keep it.

Second Corinthians 3:17 says:

"Now the Lord is that Spirit:
and where the Spirit of the Lord is,
there is liberty."

Is Paul saying the Lord Jesus is the Holy Spirit? No. The Holy Spirit is the third Person of the Godhead, not the second.

The Lord is that spirit in the sense that the Spirit of Christ is what you receive when you are born again. Before I was born again, I had the spirit of Adam, not Adam's human spirit, but the same spiritual death inherited from him. I had my own spirit, but it was in death.

As the Father has life within Himself, He gave to the Son to have life within Himself. Jesus has His own human spirit. When I was born again, Jesus gave me to have life within myself. I do not have Jesus' human spirit, but I have the Spirit of Christ because my human spirit was quickened together with Him.

That is the Spirit of the Lord the Jew must receive to be born again. Where that spirit is, there is liberty. In the presence of the law, the man is now free because he has the nature that can keep what the law described.

Second Corinthians 3:18 says:

"But we all, with open face beholding as in a glass the glory of the Lord,
are changed into the same image from glory to glory,
even as by the Spirit of the Lord."

Open face means the veil is gone. Spiritual death no longer covers the heart. We can look into the new nature and understand God.

With open face, we behold as in a mirror the glory of the Lord and are changed into the same image from glory to glory. There is no veil, no hindrance, no death, no misunderstanding. We have been translated out of darkness into the kingdom of light.

Romans 5 says that as spiritual death reigned through sin, grace and righteousness reign in this new life. Spiritual death could carry a man all the way into the capacity of death. But the abundance of grace through righteousness reigns in the new nature all the way to eternal life.

If flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom, then flesh and blood cannot be the part being perfected from glory to glory. The part of me going from glory to glory is my spirit, until the flesh does not seem to be the same problem anymore.

You are something in Christ.

Second Corinthians 4:1-4 says:

"Therefore seeing we have this ministry,
as we have received mercy,
we faint not;
But have renounced the hidden things of dishonesty,
not walking in craftiness,
nor handling the word of God deceitfully;
but by manifestation of the truth commending ourselves to every man's conscience in the
sight of God.
But if our gospel be hid,
it is hid to them that are lost:
In whom the god of this world hath blinded the minds of them which believe not."

Paul is still dealing with the veil and, in particular, with the Jew. The God of this world, not Jehovah, blinded the minds of those who believe not, lest the light of the glorious gospel of Christ, who is the image of God, should shine to them.

We do not preach ourselves, but Christ Jesus the Lord.

Second Corinthians 4:6 says:

"For God, who commanded the light to shine out of darkness,
hath shined in our hearts,
to give the light of the knowledge of the glory of God
in the face of Jesus Christ."

That is the born-again experience. A moment before, I was spiritually dead, but God commanded light to shine out of my darkness. He shined into my heart.

John said:

"In him was life;
and the life was the light of men."

Jesus was the first Man in four thousand years to be born spiritually alive. That life was my light. The light shined in darkness, and then God shined that light into my heart.

All the knowledge of the glory of the Father shines in the face of Jesus Christ. He is my Messiah. He is my Redeemer. He is the express image of God. He is my Savior.

If they are blinded, it is not by mighty Jehovah. It is by the God of this world, and it has been so for two thousand years.

I have been born again. I have surrendered all excuses for justifying failure. The main reason I surrendered them is that I do not need them anymore.

Why justify a failure when I can triumph over it? I will not do that unless I turn the Holy Ghost loose in everything Jesus made me when I was born again.

I used to blame people. But where does another person get the power to control my life? To what degree am I successful? To the degree that I cannot be stopped by you, by my family, by my spouse, by business, or by circumstances.

If sin has really lost dominion, who will I blame next for my failure?

This is why I love praying in tongues so much. You may think you need one thing, but God may know you need deliverance in another area. The Holy Ghost prays the plan of God and brings the new nature forward.

I have been born again. Hallelujah.